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SMARTER BENEFITS. STRONGER BUSINESSES.

The Complete Benefits Strategy

How Smart Employers Are Cutting Costs, Protecting Employees, and Building Benefits That Actually Work

Confidential | For Employer Presentation Only

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INTRODUCTION

Why Most Employers Are Overpaying — And Don’t Know It

If you are like most small to mid-size employers, you have accepted rising health insurance premiums as a fact of life. Every year, the renewal comes in higher. Every year, you have the same conversation about what to cut, what to keep, and how to absorb the increase. And every year, the carrier wins.

What most employers have never been shown is that there is a fundamentally different way to structure employee benefits — one that gives you control, transparency, and the ability to reduce costs without reducing coverage quality.

This guide walks you through the complete Ascend Benefits strategy. It is the same framework we use with every employer we work with, and it works because it layers the right programs in the right order — each one protecting and amplifying the one before it.

By the time you finish reading, you will understand exactly how employers just like you are saving up to 30% on their health plan costs, giving employees access to better care, and funding benefits they never thought were within reach — all without spending more than they already are.

The Ascend Strategy in Four Steps

1. Replace your traditional plan with a Level Funded or RBP health plan.
2. Layer a Preventive Care Management Program to protect claims and generate tax savings.
3. Use those savings to fund a Gap plan that eliminates employee out-of-pocket exposure.
4. Direct remaining savings toward dental, vision, disability, life, and voluntary benefits.

PART ONE

The Problem With Traditional Insurance

How Traditional Insurance Works

Most employers are on what is called a fully insured plan. It is the model that has dominated the market for decades, and for good reason. The employer pays a fixed monthly premium to a carrier, the carrier pools that money with every other group they insure, and claims get paid out of that pool.

The problem is what happens behind the scenes.

Why Your Premiums Go Up Every Year

Because the carrier controls all the risk, they also control all the pricing. At renewal, they look at their entire book of business — not just your group — and adjust rates accordingly. Even if your employees had a healthy year, your renewal can still climb because other groups in the pool had expensive claims. Your healthy workforce is subsidizing someone else's sick one, and you will never know it.

The national average premium increase for fully insured group plans runs between 8 and 11% per year. Compounded over five years, that is a dramatically more expensive plan with no guarantee your coverage improved at all.

You Have No Idea What You Are Paying For

In a traditional plan, the carrier holds all your claims data and is under no obligation to share it. You pay your premium and your visibility ends there. No report showing what is driving costs, no data to help you negotiate at renewal, no information to make smarter decisions. You are simply accepting whatever number the carrier puts in front of you next year.

The Carrier Wins Either Way

If your group has a bad year with high claims, premiums go up. If your group has a great year with low claims, the carrier keeps the surplus. There is no reward for healthy groups and no transparency for employers who want to take control. That is not a benefits strategy. That is just writing a check every month and hoping for the best.

Most Brokers Never Show You Another Option

The traditional insurance model is what most brokers know, and it is what they sell. Not because it is the best solution for your business, but because it is the most familiar one. The result is that the majority of small and mid-size employers have never been shown what a smarter, more cost-effective benefits structure looks like.

> "That is what Ascend does differently!"

PART TWO

A Smarter Health Plan Foundation

There Is a Better Way to Structure Your Health Plan

The good news is that fully insured plans are not the only option. Two alternatives — Level Funded plans and Reference Based Pricing — give employers more control, more transparency, and real opportunities to reduce costs without sacrificing coverage quality. Ascend builds every benefits package on one of these two foundations.

Level Funded Plans — Predictability With Payback

A level funded plan works similarly to traditional insurance from the employee's perspective — same ID cards, same PPO networks, same copay structure. The difference is how the money flows behind the scenes.

Instead of paying a premium to a carrier who keeps everything, the employer pays a fixed monthly amount split into three parts: a claims fund, stop-loss insurance, and an administrative fee. If your employees have a healthy year and claims come in under projection, the unused dollars in the claims fund can be returned to you at year end as a surplus refund. The carrier no longer wins either way. You do.

Level funded plans also come with full claims transparency. You can see exactly what's driving costs, which services are being used, and how your group is performing throughout the year. That data puts you in control at renewal instead of at the mercy of whatever number the carrier decides to charge. Available for groups as small as two employees.

Reference Based Pricing — Maximum Savings, Maximum Freedom

Reference Based Pricing takes a fundamentally different approach to how providers get paid. Instead of reimbursing hospitals and physicians at negotiated network rates — which are discounts off artificially inflated prices — RBP reimburses providers at a transparent percentage above what Medicare pays for the same service.

The result is a plan that eliminates the chargemaster game entirely. Employees can see any licensed provider in the country with no network restrictions, and costs are anchored to a real, reliable benchmark rather than a number a carrier negotiated for their own benefit. RBP plans consistently trend at 5% or more below traditional PPO cost increases year over year.

Which One Is Right for You?

	Level Funded	Reference Based Pricing
Monthly Cost	Fixed and predictable	Fixed and predictable
Provider Access	PPO Network	Any licensed provider
Claims Transparency	Full	Full
Surplus Refund Potential	Yes	No
Employee Disruption	Minimal	Requires education
Best For	Savings with familiar experience	Maximum cost reduction

These are not competing products. There are two different tools to solve the same problem. Traditional insurance costs too much, rewards carriers, and leaves employers in the dark. The right choice depends on your workforce, your goals, and where you want to be. Either way, both plans perform significantly better when they are paired with the next layer of the Ascend strategy.

PART THREE

Layering the

Preventive Care Program

The Smartest Thing You Can Do for Your Health Plan Is Keep Claims Off of It

Every claim filed against your major medical plan has a cost. Not just the dollar amount of the claim itself, but the long-term impact it has on your utilization rate, your renewal pricing, and your ability to capture a surplus refund at year end. The fewer claims that hit your health plan, the better your plan performs.

That is exactly what the Preventive Care Management Program does.

What Is the PCMP?

The Preventive Care Management Program is a comprehensive wellness benefit delivered through the Revive Health platform. It gives every employee direct access to real, everyday healthcare at no cost to them and no claim filed against the major medical plan.

When an employee has a sick child, a nagging health question, a prescription they need refilled, or a mental health concern they have been putting off, Revive Health is their first call. Not the emergency room. Not their primary care office with a three week wait. Revive.

What Employees Get

Service	What It Delivers
Primary Care	Board-certified physicians, Mon–Fri. No copay, no deductible. Most consults within 1–3 days. Covers hypertension, diabetes, allergies, respiratory issues, and ongoing primary care needs.
Urgent Care, 24/7	Any time, anywhere. Over 90% of consults connected within 3 minutes. Eliminates unnecessary ER visits that would otherwise become claims.
Mental Health	Access to master’s-level clinicians around the clock. Appointments within 5 days. 88% of members attend their first session, compared to 30–40% for traditional EAPs.
Pharmacy	A formulary of 1,000+ maintenance medications and 70+ acute medications delivered free to the employee’s home. No pharmacy copay. No claim.
Weight Health	Physician-supervised weight management including GLP-1 medication access, personalized coaching, and fitness content.

Why This Matters for Your Health Plan

Every time an employee uses Revive Health instead of their major medical plan, that is one less claim driving up your utilization. Fewer claims mean lower costs at renewal, a stronger position going into each plan year, and a greater likelihood of receiving a surplus refund if you are on a level funded plan.

This is not a wellness perk. It is a claims protection strategy built directly into your benefits package. And how it is funded will be covered in detail later in this document. What matters here is that the net cost to the employer is zero.

The program can also be added at any time. No open enrollment required. No disruption to your existing plan.

PART FOUR

The Gap Plan

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Protecting Employees From the Bills That Actually Break the Bank

Even a well-structured health plan leaves employees exposed. Deductibles, coinsurance, and out-of-pocket costs are built into every major medical plan by design. For most employees, those costs sit in the background until something actually happens. And when something does happen, the bill that shows up can be devastating.

An $8,500 emergency room visit with a deductible not yet met. A $25,000 hospital admission with 80/20 coinsurance kicking in after. These are not worst-case scenarios. These are everyday situations that catch employees completely off guard and create real financial hardship.

That is the gap. And it is exactly why closing it is the first voluntary benefit Ascend puts in place before dental, before vision, before anything else.

Why Gap Coverage

The Gap plan pays cash directly to the employee or directly to providers to cover what their major medical plan does not. Deductibles, coinsurance, and out-of-pocket expenses that would otherwise come out of an employee’s paycheck are covered by the Gap plan instead.

It pairs directly with the health plan so that the health plan handles the major medical exposure and the Gap plan handles what is left. The employee walks away from a hospital stay, a surgery, or an emergency room visit without a bill they cannot pay.

Ascend always places the lowest deductible Gap plan available in your state. Depending on state regulations that can be as low as zero, though in some states it may be up to $1,000. Either way, the goal is the same — to get employees as close to zero out of pocket as possible.

What It Looks Like in the Real World

The table below shows what an employee would owe with a zero deductible Gap plan in place compared to having no Gap coverage at all.

	Without Gap	With a Zero Deductible Gap
$8,500 ER visit, deductible not met	Employee owes $5,000	**Employee owes $0**
$25,000 hospital admission, 80/20 coinsurance	Employee owes $5,000	**Employee owes $0**

Why It Comes First

A cracked tooth is painful. A $20,000 hospital stay can financially ruin someone. Ascend prioritizes the Gap plan because it protects employees from the kind of financial exposure that dental and vision coverage never will. Once that protection is in place, additional benefits can be layered on top to build out a truly complete package.

The Gap plan premium may be covered in most cases through the same program that funds the PCMP at no net cost to the employer or the employee. How that works is explained in the next section.

PART FIVE

The Full Picture

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This Is Where It All Comes Together

Every piece of the Ascend strategy serves a purpose. The health plan foundation controls cost and puts transparency back in the employer's hands. The PCMP keeps everyday claims off the major medical plan. The Gap plan protects employees from the out-of-pocket exposure that even a good health plan leaves behind. When these pieces are built and layered in the right order, the result is a benefits package that most employers never thought was within reach.

Step 1 — Replace the Traditional Plan With a Level Funded Plan

The first move is straightforward. The employer transitions off their traditional fully insured plan and onto a level funded health plan. Same coverage quality, same employee experience, but with a structure that works in the employer's favor.

Level funded plans can save employers up to 30% compared to what they are currently paying on a traditional plan. Claims data become fully visible. Surplus refund potential is built in. And the employer is no longer subsidizing other groups they have never met.

This alone is a significant improvement. But it is just the starting point.

Step 2 — Implement the PCMP Through EHP and Revive Health

On top of the level funded plan, Ascend layers a Preventive Care Management Program administered through EHP and delivered via the Revive Health platform. Employees gain free access to primary care, urgent care, mental health services, and pharmacy benefits. Everyday care stays off the major medical plan. Claims drop. The health plan performs better at renewal.

But here is what makes this more than just a wellness program.

When the Affordable Care Act was passed, Congress included a specific provision that allows employers who implement a qualifying Preventive Care Program to use a special pre-tax payroll structure. This is not a loophole. It is built directly into the law. Employers who qualify can run the cost of the wellness program through a Section 125 Cafeteria Plan, reducing each employee's taxable income. The employee sees no change in their take-home pay. The employer generates FICA tax savings of up to $1,120 per enrolled employee per year. The program funds itself. The net cost to the employer is zero.

Step 3 — The Tax Savings Cover the Gap Plan

Those tax savings do not stop covering the PCMP. In most cases they are sufficient to cover the Gap plan premium as well, meaning employees receive protection from deductibles, coinsurance, and out-of-pocket exposure at no additional cost to anyone.

Step 4 — Build Out the Rest

Any remaining savings can be directed toward dental, vision, disability, life insurance, accident, and critical illness coverage — giving employees a benefits package that most companies their size have never been able to offer.

Traditional Benefits vs. The Ascend Strategy

Traditional Benefits	The Ascend Strategy
Health plan costs rising 8 to 11% per year	**Up to 30% savings with level funded**
Employee pays copays and deductibles for everyday care	**Everyday care is free through Revive Health**
No claims data access	**Full claims transparency**
No surplus refund potential	**Surplus refund potential at year end**
No employer tax savings	**Up to $1,120 per employee per year**
Deductibles and coinsurance out of pocket	**Covered by the Gap plan**
Additional benefits cost more	**Funded through tax savings**
Premiums rising every year	**Controlled and transparent**

This Is Not a Trade-Off

Better benefits do not have to mean higher costs. They just must be structured correctly. The Ascend strategy is not about finding a cheaper plan and hoping employees do not notice. It is about building something smarter — a package that protects the employer's bottom line, protects the employee's wallet, and delivers a level of coverage that most companies never thought was within reach.

This is what it looks like when benefits are done right.

Ready to Build a Smarter Benefits Package?

Schedule your free benefits analysis today.

No obligation. Clear answers from an independent consultant.

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